



ARUN T. RAMCHANDANI looks out of the window of his sparsely furnished room at L&T's office in Powai, Mumbai and remembers the early days. He joined the organisation straight from IIT Delhi in 1984 after graduating with a degree in mechanical engineering. "Even then, there was a joy in manufacturing," he says.

Four decades is a long time and in the context of how technology has evolved to engulf our lives within this time, it suddenly seems even longer. As Executive VP at L&T Defence, Ramchandani is in the midst of a decisive phase of the Indian manufacturing story. The pressure on China is palpable and India—from being a modest challenger a decade ago to becoming a versatile player well on its way to consolidating its position globally—has come a long way. Of course, the long and arduous journey ahead is not going to be easy, and a lot of things need to fall in place, from flawless execution to the correct strategy, to achieve the desired results.

"We never had enablers like 3D CAD (computer-aided design), or advanced CMM (coordinate measuring machine) systems. There used to be a heavy engineering and switchgear factory here, and we had to go to Tata Institute of Fundamental Research to run our programs," narrates Ramchandani. If that is harking back to a bygone era, he is hugely chuffed about what he sees today. Just in the defence sphere, L&T today has a large spread of product

offerings, among which are land-, air- and naval-based weapon systems and communications to name just a few.

Arguably, Indian manufacturing has never had it so good. There is a sense of optimism in the industry that is flush with a talented workforce and backed by the willingness of large global and domestic firms to cut the big cheques. The building blocks of creating a compelling manufacturing tale by 2047 looks good, and it is up to the stakeholders to make the most of the opportunity.

A T 14 PER cent of India's GDP, manufacturing, says K.C. Jhanwar, MD of UltraTech Cement, is expected to grow by 9 per cent over the next five years. "This is distinctly much more than many other countries in Asia. We have a huge labour supply with more than half the population under 30; and in terms of cost per hour, India is at about a quarter of China (92 cents here, compared to \$3.5 there). More importantly, we have a skilled labour base coupled with the second-largest English-speaking population after the US," he points out. For international majors looking to make India a global hub, it is a seriously attractive proposition. "Of course, there is also the domestic market with a huge untapped opportunity."

What enthuses Ramchandani is how the younger lot

STRONG POTENTIAL...



- ① Significant progress in manufacturing in India in the last decade
- ② AtmaNirbharBharat and Make in India initiatives have been triggers
- ③ Policy initiatives have created a favourable environment with nearly 270 operational SEZs
- ④ GST, National Single Window System, PLI expected to boost manufacturing
- ⑤ Manufacturing can create 60-70 million jobs by 2030